Making examples and references accessible

Practical guide for subject lecturers | D09-S1–S6

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An example can introduce an additional difficulty if students are unfamiliar with its setting or references. Explain the background they need and show how the example connects to the subject concept. Familiarity will vary within any group; avoid making assumptions based on students' ethnicity, nationality or English proficiency.

1. Identify background knowledge the example requires

Before teaching, review your example for assumed knowledge. Consider whether students need to understand a particular institution, event, everyday practice or technical process.

Briefly check that knowledge with the whole class.

Example — Business: Before using a supermarket loyalty scheme to explain customer retention, ask: "What does a loyalty scheme offer customers? Why might a business use one?"

Use the responses to decide what to explain. Avoid asking an individual to speak for a cultural or ethnic group.

2. Provide the context needed to understand

Give a short introduction covering the information needed for the task. A photograph, labelled diagram or brief description may help.

Example — Business: "In this example, customers collect points when they shop. They can exchange the points for discounts. We will examine whether this encourages customers to return."

Students now have the context needed to analyse the scheme. They do not need a detailed history of the retailer.
For an international case, explain any relevant differences in institutions or practices rather than assuming they work the same way everywhere.

3. Make the connection to the subject concept explicit

After introducing an example, state what it illustrates. Identify which features matter and why.

Example — Business: "The important feature is the reward for returning. We are using this example to examine customer retention: how a business encourages existing customers to continue buying."

For an analogy, explain both the useful comparison and its limits.

Example — Engineering: "Water flow can help us visualise electrical current. A restriction in a pipe offers a comparison with resistance. However, water and electrical circuits behave differently, so we must check which relationships the comparison can explain."

Specify the relevant relationships accurately for the topic you are teaching.

4. Use contrasting examples from different contexts

Show the same concept in two settings. Ask students to identify what stays the same and what changes. Example — Economics: opportunity cost

Situation	Choice	Opportunity cost
A student has time for either a paid shift or a study session.	The student chooses to study.	The earnings from the shift they give up.
A business can fund either new equipment or an advertising campaign.	The business chooses the equipment.	The benefit of the advertising campaign it gives up.

Explain: "Both examples involve choosing between alternatives. The opportunity cost is the value of the next-best alternative forgone."

Invite further examples, but have alternatives prepared yourself. Students should not have to disclose personal circumstances to participate.

5. Explain references, idioms and humour that carry meaning

Check whether an expression is necessary for learning the subject. Explain important expressions directly; replace incidental ones where they add an unnecessary barrier.

Example — Business

- Instead of: “The new competitor has moved the goalposts.”
- Say: “The new competitor has changed the conditions in which the company operates.”

If a figurative expression is also an essential technical term, retain it and explain its disciplinary meaning.

Example — Marketing: “‘Cash cow’ has a specific meaning in the BCG matrix: a business or product with a high relative market share in a low-growth market.”

If students need a joke or cultural reference to understand your point, explain the reference or restate the point directly.

6. Check that students can apply the underlying idea

Use a short question or a new case to check whether students understand the concept beyond the original example.

Example — Business; After discussing supermarket loyalty points, ask: “A café offers a free drink after several purchases. How might this encourage customer retention? What would we need to know before judging whether it works?”

If students struggle, check the context and concept separately:

- “First, how does the café’s offer work?”
- “Now, how could that influence a customer’s decision to return?”

This helps you decide whether to explain the example’s setting, revisit the subject concept or clarify the connection between them.

A short routine to try

Choose one example from your next lesson:

1. Identify the background knowledge it assumes.
2. Prepare a brief explanation of that context.
3. State explicitly what the example illustrates.
4. Prepare a second example.
5. Ask students to apply the concept to the new setting.

Supporting Sources

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